

British RP Pronunciation Assessment Checklist

Eric Ola-Solomon | Highfield Level 5 TEFL (High Distinction) | 9+ Years | thriveenglish.co

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Read each sound description aloud. Record yourself if possible. Answer honestly — this is for your benefit, not a test. Score yourself at the end to find your focus area.

PART 1 — VOWEL SOUNDS

1. The Schwa /ə/ — “about”, “open”, “bacon”

Self-test: Say “photograph” aloud. Does the first syllable sound relaxed and unstressed, or do you give it full weight?

Common mistake: Giving every syllable equal stress. In British RP, unstressed syllables collapse to schwa.

[I struggle with this sound](#)

2. Short A /æ/ — “cat”, “bat”, “hat”

Self-test: Say “cat” and “cart”. Do they sound different? The /æ/ should be very open, mouth wide.

Common mistake: Replacing with /a/ as in “father” — “cat” becoming “cart”.

[I struggle with this sound](#)

3. Long AR /ɑ:/ — “car”, “bath”, “fast”

Self-test: Say “bath”. Does it rhyme with “math” (American) or “hearth” (British)? It should rhyme with “hearth” in RP.

Common mistake: Using the short /æ/ for BATH words — a very common Nigerian/West African pattern.

[I struggle with this sound](#)

4. Long EE /i:/ — “see”, “feet”, “machine”

Self-test: Say “feel” and “fill”. Do they sound different? The /i:/ should be longer and tenser.

Common mistake: Shortening /i:/ so “feel” sounds like “fill”.

[I struggle with this sound](#)

5. The Short OO /ʊ/ — “book”, “put”, “good”

Self-test: Say “pool” and “pull”. Do they sound different? “Pull” should have a short, relaxed /ʊ/.

Common mistake: Using the long /u:/ for both — “book” sounding like “boot”.

[I struggle with this sound](#)

PART 2 — CONSONANT SOUNDS

6. TH Soft /θ/ — "think", "bath", "three"

Self-test: Say "think". Is your tongue tip between or just behind your teeth? You should feel air passing over your tongue.

Common mistake: Replacing with /t/ or /f/ — "think" becoming "tink" or "fink".

I struggle with this sound

7. TH Hard /ð/ — "the", "this", "that"

Self-test: Say "they". Feel your throat vibrate? The /ð/ is voiced — your vocal cords should hum.

Common mistake: Replacing with /d/ — "the" becoming "de", "this" becoming "dis".

I struggle with this sound

8. The R Sound /r/ — "red", "right", "very"

Self-test: Say "red". In British RP, the R is softer than American English — tongue tip curls slightly, never touches the roof of the mouth.

Common mistake: Trilling or rolling the R, or using a hard American R.

I struggle with this sound

9. V vs W — "van" vs "wan", "very" vs "wary"

Self-test: Say "vine" and "wine". For /v/, your top teeth should touch your lower lip. For /w/, lips round without teeth contact.

Common mistake: Replacing /v/ with /w/ — "very" becoming "wery".

I struggle with this sound

10. Word Stress Patterns

Self-test: Say "photograph", "photography", "photographic". Does the stress shift? PHOtograph → phoTOgraphy → photoGRAPHic.

Common mistake: Keeping stress fixed on the same syllable regardless of word form.

I struggle with this sound

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YOUR SCORE

Count your ticks:

0–2 ticked: Strong foundation. Focus on refining stress and intonation patterns.

3–5 ticked: Moderate challenges. Targeted work on your specific sounds will produce quick results.

6–8 ticked: Several areas need attention. A structured programme working through vowels first, then consonants, is recommended.

9–10 ticked: Significant challenges across multiple areas. A personalised coaching programme will give you the fastest, most efficient path forward.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Practice the sounds yourself:

Visit soundcode44.thriveenglish.co — every sound on this checklist has its own interactive card with audio, spelling patterns, and tips.

Get personalised guidance:

Book a free 25-minute Voice Profile Session with Eric at thriveenglish.co/coaching — he'll assess exactly which sounds to prioritise for your goals.

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